

Towards unreality but for what joy?



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Before I get on with my rant, let me be very clear that it's not for lack of joy or a sense of achievement that I'm cautious of my enthusiasm to a higher reality – and I'm not talking about transcendence here, the movie or the concept. Like many of you, I too want to put on the Oculus Rift and get truly immersed into a game like nothing I've ever felt before, or get into a 4D simulator to walk on Mars without actually going there. I eagerly await the sensory overload that is the inevitable augmented, hyper-real world of the future.

However, there are some major hurdles in the path of our realization of a successful meta reality (virtual or hyper), and the road from idea to actualization and mass acceptance is a long and arduous one, to say the least. It's definitely not something happening overnight. And we have to be patient, and refrain from getting ahead of ourselves.

Take the case of a cutting edge (hyperreal?) project that got all of us excited here in the Digit team, and plenty of others around the world: the driverless Google Car that's in the works. This autonomous robotic vehicle – which could be any current sedan running on the road, equipped with Google's advanced on-road GPS navigation system and 360 degree camera – is fast closing on to its 1 million mile mark. Imagine a car driving itself to the moon three times over, with no driver, and no accidents. Does that mean all of its technological problems are resolved? Far from it.

Several challenges abound Google's driverless car project, according to critics and autonomous driving researchers. Google's cars, for example, can't drive on a non-map based navigation system, and require extensive preparation (studying routes, traffic signal locations, traffic direction, etc) before embarking upon their journey. What happens if a traffic signal malfunctions on its route? The car is left in a tight spot, needless to say. What's more, as of now the car isn't capable of parking itself in a large empty parking complex (forget a tiny one), is still untested in snowy or rainy conditions, and Google has plans to make all its future cars driverless – without even a steering wheel! So even the faintest possibility of a human

intervening to take control of one of these things to avert disaster is out of the question. Also, there's no answer to the classic question: if a driverless car crashes into something, who's to be blamed? How is any piece of legislation going to give such a trendsetting technology with no safeguards the opportunity to conduct road tests, let alone market and sell the dream? As much as we'd like to see this happen quickly, we are definitely not going to witness a driverless car on the road for a long time still.

Wherever hyperreality or meta-reality meets the physical world, the stakes are immensely high and we don't seem to have any clear roadmap of seamlessly integrating the two. If a doctor were to wear an advanced HUD to conduct a precision surgery from a remote location, lives will be saved, no doubt, and such niche applications of path-breaking technology are prevalent in numerous fields. But always in controlled environments. Giving intrusive immersive contraptions and gadgets to the public en masse, and expecting them to coexist with others without pandemonium breaking out is a utopian dream which even hyperreality cannot realise. Why? Because we can't seem to negate the possibility of crashing into a pole while talking on a phone while driving. To get into a full-blown immersive virtual reality experience deeply linked to the real world is nothing short of a calamitous situation. Forget the question of systems – I'm sure with enough time, money and talent, we will build full-proof systems. But what about our own mental handicap? We can't see current-generation stereoscopic 3D movies for too long without inducing a headache or developing an eyesore. What if all this advanced virtual reality mumbo jumbo is just too much for our physical body to handle? What if all this simply isn't meant to be?

Think about it and drop me a line. I'd love to hear your views on this topic. 

Got feedback about this column?
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